

WEEK 3 LESSON GUIDE

WONDER

BIG IDEA

We worship because God is faithful.

BIBLE

Psalm 34:17–20, 77:11–12;
Hebrews 12:1–2

ABOUT THIS WEEK

Approaching a majestic waterfall, you can feel its thundering roar, unrelenting cascade, and steady power—it never stops flowing, just like God’s faithfulness never runs dry. This week, we’re reminded God isn’t distant but closer than we know, ready to protect, deliver, and walk with us through every challenge we face. As we stand in awe of God’s unchanging presence, **we worship because God is faithful.**

WHAT? What are we talking about?



See the Middle
School Hacks



ACTIVITY | Niagara River Relay

- Welcome back to Week 3 of *Wonder*! We've spent time discovering some of the world's natural wonders, which have helped us learn about worshiping the God who created us. Natural wonders are massive creations that take our breath away. They're so amazing that they often leave us speechless.
- Some people look at these wonders a little differently. Instead of being amazed, they might think, "I should ride a barrel over that!" Well, at least that was the case with Niagara Falls.
- In 1901, Annie Edson Taylor decided to ride a customized pickle barrel over this giant waterfall, and she survived! Let's play a quick game to honor her work and explore what it's like to be stuck in a barrel.
- **INSTRUCTIONS:** *For this activity, you'll need large trash cans, bowls of water, cones or tape, and plenty of space. Use the cones or tape to create a zigzag course from one end of the playing area to the other. Split your group into two or more teams. One leg of the relay could have one player sit or lie inside the trash can with two team members pulling them around the course until they reach the other side. Another leg could have a person inside holding a bowl of water. Their teammates move the trash can through the course, attempting not to spill any water. The team that completes the course with the most water remaining wins. Repeat with new players for as many legs of the relay as you want.*
- Congrats! You survived our makeshift river relay. I can tell that wasn't nearly as easy as floating down a river, but you didn't have to worry about a 175-foot drop into the abyss!

DISCUSSION

- **INSTRUCTIONS:** *If you have more than 15 students, skip this discussion and*



See the
Accessibility Hacks

save it for small groups. If you conduct this discussion, the starred questions are designed for high schoolers, so you may want to skip them for middle schoolers.

- ***How much money would it take to convince you to go over a giant waterfall in a barrel?**
- **Which would you rather do, walk over a waterfall on a tightrope or go over one in a barrel?**

IMAGE | An Image of Victoria Falls

- I love Niagara Falls, but did you know it's not one of the World's Natural Wonders? Sure, it's the largest waterfall by volume in the United States, but it's nowhere near the size of the largest waterfall in the world.
- **INSTRUCTIONS:** As a teaching tool, show an image of Victoria Falls, like [this one](#) or [this one](#). [Read this](#) for more information on legally using copyrighted material for educational purposes!
- This is Victoria Falls. It's the largest waterfall on Earth and one of the Seven Natural Wonders of the World. It's over a mile long and stands over 350 feet tall. Not only is it an incredible sight to take in, Victoria Falls is also an important part of the ecosystem in the African countries Zambia and Zimbabwe.
- Where there's water, there's life, and Victoria Falls is home to all sorts of plants and animals that rely on water to live and thrive. The people and animals in the area count on the consistent flow of water over the tops of the falls. They rest easy knowing the falls will provide what they need. The faithful sound and sight of the waterfall no doubt comfort everyone who relies on it.



See the Hacks

QUESTION | Who are faithful people in your life?

- Maybe you know what it's like to stand in front of a reliable and consistent presence—something you know you can trust. It might not be a giant waterfall but a friend or relative.
- **INSTRUCTIONS:** Ask the following questions and give a few students an opportunity to respond.
 - **Who are some faithful people in your life?**
 - **What do they do to show you that you can trust them?**
- When our lives feel upside down, these are the first people we may turn to. They tend to understand us better than anyone else. Because of their faithful and predictable character, just being with them can make us feel safe.
- These people are sort of like Victoria Falls. They are big parts of our lives and can help us tap into the even bigger, better, more wonderful example of faithfulness we can experience. Let's take a look.

SO WHAT? Why does it matter to God and to us?



See the High
School Hacks

SCRIPTURE | Psalm 34:17–20

- When we get down to it, faithfulness is about choosing to stick around even when things aren't perfect. A faithful friend is with us even when we're not the best version of ourselves. A faithful coach stays with the team even if the season isn't

a good one. Faithfulness is about sticking it out, no matter what.

- As we turn back to the book of Psalms—that collection of poems and songs about God's character—we'll see how these authors understood God's faithfulness in their lives. Let's take a look at how one writer describes one of these experiences.
- **INSTRUCTIONS:** Read Psalm 34:17–20.
- Two different characteristics of God stand out in this psalm: God as a deliverer and God as a protector.
 - The author described God as someone who releases people from trouble—that's deliverance.
 - Then, we read that God shields as well—that's protection.
- The attributes of God as deliverer and protector characterize the same unchanging truth: God is immensely faithful to us. Have you ever had someone disappear when your life became challenging? Maybe some relationships started to spin out of control, or you developed some habits that weren't the best for you. When you went to look for help, your friends couldn't be found, or worse, they didn't care.
- That's *not* the picture we get of God in this psalm. God is described as being close. God hears our cries and is close enough to rescue people who feel broken.
- God is faithful to us in our troubles, not standing at a distance watching our next move. God is the strong, tethered rope when you feel like you're drifting over the edge of the waterfall. Faithfully, God is nearby, waiting to be invited in. Once we extend that invitation, we can be sure God will step in to rescue us—even if it doesn't look the way we imagine.
- It's that faithfulness—that desire to be close to us always—that's as amazing as watching tons of water pour over the top of Victoria Falls. It's truly awe-inspiring to think about how God cares about us so deeply. The psalmist experienced this type of faithfulness and had to write it down.
- If worship flows from our experiences, then this psalm is worship in response to the experience of God's unwavering faithfulness. While we may not see it right away, God's faithfulness can be found when we look deeper.

VIDEO | A Clip of Christ The Redeemer

- When life gets tough, it can be hard for us to remember God's faithfulness. We might *want* to look at the bigger picture, but maybe we're unable to look past the challenges right in front of us at the moment. If we face a bunch of challenges back-to-back, it's even easier to lose sight of God's faithfulness and presence in our lives.
- That's one reason a statue of Jesus was built in Rio de Janeiro. In 1931, this 125-foot-tall statue was officially completed. It's located on a mountain overlooking the whole city. Let's take a look!
- **INSTRUCTIONS:** As a teaching tool, play a [short clip](#) (0:00–2:00) of drone footage of Christ the Redeemer or something like it. We always suggest viewing the clip beforehand to ensure you think it's a video that will be a good fit for your context! [Read this](#) for more information on legally using copyrighted material for educational purposes!
- This statue and the view from its location are so incredible that they are one of the New Seven Wonders of the World! The classification is impressive, and so is

what the statue represents.

- Any time you need a reminder of God's faithfulness, you could just look up at the mountains behind the city. Can you imagine that? In case you don't live in Rio de Janeiro, we can *all* see examples of God's faithfulness in the world when we choose to notice.

SCRIPTURE | Hebrews 12:1–2

- Scripture has hundreds of stories about God's faithfulness to people. It's not just the psalms, either. We can read all sorts of stories about God's presence in the lives of many people. The best example is found in Jesus. Jesus was born on Earth to help people see what God was like and to experience God's presence in the world.
- **INSTRUCTIONS:** Read Hebrews 12:1–2.
- Jesus was so faithful to people that he was willing to die for us. He wasn't forced to do this—it was described as a "joy." Jesus understood the importance of demonstrating faithfulness for us. He knew we would need reminders that God is with us when we lose sight of God's love. Jesus chose to be the ultimate example of God's faithfulness.
- Jesus' faithfulness on the cross led artists to create art like the incredible statue towering over Rio de Janeiro. His choice to die so we could have a relationship with God gives us a great reason to respond in worship.
- When we respond to God's faithfulness with worship, we're pointing to truths beyond our understanding. It doesn't matter if you're still learning about worship or if you have questions about how to worship God best. You don't need to know anything at all, really. We worship because we're inspired to respond to the wonder of what God has done.
- You might worship by...
 - Writing a song or a poem about God's faithfulness like the writers of the Psalms did.
 - Sharing stories of God's faithfulness in your life.
 - Being an example of God's faithfulness in the world by sticking with someone.
 - Going out into nature and taking in the wonder of all that's been created.
- Faithfulness is about being present in good and bad times. Scripture shows us how God is present and close to us always. No matter how difficult the world may seem, God is there with us.

DISCUSSION

- **INSTRUCTIONS:** If you have more than 15 students, skip this discussion and save it for small groups. If you conduct this discussion, the starred questions are designed for high schoolers, so you may want to skip them for middle schoolers.
 - **When was a time you cried out to God for help? How did God respond?**
 - ***How does knowing there are generations before you of faithful Jesus followers help you in your own faith journey?**
 - **Read Psalm 77:11–12. What events can you mark in your life to remember how God has been faithful to you?**



See the Middle
School Hacks



Share your story



STORY | Reflecting On God's Faithfulness

- God's faithfulness will always be with us—we can see it in Jesus. But faithfulness is a trait best understood after a long time. You wouldn't ask a friend for help and then call them faithful after one experience. Sure, they're *helpful*, but faithfulness and consistency are most clearly seen over time.
- **INSTRUCTIONS:** *Tell a story about a time in your life when you experienced God's faithfulness. Share about a moment when it wasn't quite clear that God was showing faithfulness. How did you respond at first? How did you recognize God's faithfulness? In what ways did your response look like worship? You can also invite a few volunteers to share their experiences.*
- Scripture often points us to God's faithfulness. We see it in stories that tell us how God was close to people. We see it in the gift of our friends and family, who model God's faithfulness when our lives are difficult. And we see it in Jesus.
- God has done so much to help us recognize faithfulness, going above and beyond so we can know that God is close to us. We're invited to respond to that faithfulness with worship with each story, song, or poem. So, **we worship because God is faithful.**

NOW WHAT? What does God want us to do about it?



Use your Gifts



OBJECT LESSON | Seeing God's Faithfulness

- When we feel discouraged, God's faithfulness might not be the first thing we seek. We might want God to fix something instead. But if we're not careful, those feelings can keep us from worshiping God with our words and our lives.
- There will always be challenges among the goodness in life. But no matter what's in front of us, we know God's faithfulness will always be there.
- **INSTRUCTIONS:** *For this object lesson, you'll need a pitcher of water, a [clear plastic cylinder](#), and several rocks small enough to fit in your cylinder. If you used the Week 2 reflection "Write To Remember," you can reuse some of those rocks. As you speak, place rocks into the cylinder one by one. Pour the pitcher of water over the rocks to demonstrate how God's faithfulness covers them.*
- Even when we feel like we have nothing but problems, God's faithfulness reaches the deepest part of our lives. It miraculously covers everything we're feeling to remind us that God is with us.
- So, how can we learn to worship even in the middle of our challenges? Here are a few ways we can focus on God when our lives feel a bit messy.
 - **REMEMBER WHEN GOD WAS FAITHFUL:** Make a habit of reflecting on your life to see God moving throughout it. Try journaling in a notebook or an app or scrolling through your photo history every few weeks. You can start a weekly conversation with a close friend about what God is doing in your life. If we want to learn to see God's faithfulness over the course of our lives, let's make time to look for it—especially when we're facing a challenge.
 - **LEARN FROM FAITHFUL PEOPLE:** Look for stories that help you remember God's faithfulness. Think about your life and learn the stories

in Scripture that show God's faithfulness to the world. Ask people around you about how they remember that faithfulness. These stories, both in Scripture and from people you know, can help you see the patterns of that faithfulness in your life so you can worship through challenges.

- **PRACTICE BEING FAITHFUL:** How can you be an example of God's faithfulness in your relationships and community? What steps can you take to show your faith to your friends and family? Practice being a faithful friend and follow through on your commitments. Show up for your friends when they need support and someone to care for them. You could even choose to invest in your community and local businesses as a sign of your faithfulness. Faithfulness isn't just a great idea—it can be shared with others every day.
- Long before we were born, God showed faithfulness to the world in creation and through Jesus' presence. The people who experience God's faithfulness responded with worship, and we can do the same. **We worship because God is faithful.**

DISCUSSION

- **INSTRUCTIONS:** *If you have more than 15 students, skip this discussion and save it for small groups. If you conduct this discussion, the starred questions are designed for high schoolers, so you may want to skip them for middle schoolers.*
 - **What about worshiping God in this way is difficult for you? How can we support you as you learn and grow?**
 - ***If you were going to share with someone what it looks like to worship because God is faithful, what would you tell them?**
 - **What is one way this week you can practice worshiping because God is faithful?**



MUSIC | "Promises" (Maverick City Music feat. Joe L Barnes & Naomi Raine)

- As we wrap up, let's reflect on the ways God has been by our side. Whether or not we're aware of it, God has been there for those who lived by faith all throughout history.
- **INSTRUCTIONS:** Play [this video](#) of the song "Promises" (Maverick City Music) and allow for a time of worshipful reflection. We always suggest viewing the clip beforehand to ensure you think it's a video that will be a good fit for your context! [Read this](#) for more information on legally using copyrighted material for educational purposes!
- Let's spend some time reflecting. As the song plays, I encourage you all to worship by thanking God for the moments in your life when you experienced God's faithfulness. If you want to, you can quietly share that experience with a friend near you.
- Throughout Scripture, we see examples of God's faithfulness to us. Even when it cost more than any of us would be willing to pay, God chose to stay faithful. Whether we find examples in our lives, in nature, or in statues that show us Jesus' outstretched arms, may we all be inspired to worship in response to God's faithfulness. **We worship because God is faithful.**